

Tennessee Comprehensive Assessment Program

TCAP

Social Studies
Grade 6
Practice Items



Which time designation fits events that happen today?

- A.** B.C.
- B.** C.E.
- C.** circa
- D.** prehistory

The excerpt describes artifacts at a prehistoric site.

Olorgesailie has important evidence that concerns the habits and activities of early prehistoric peoples of the hand axe culture. The site has the highest concentration of hand axes probably compared to any other place in the world.

— Olorgesailie Kenya Prehistoric Site, UNESCO

What makes the artifacts found at this site significant?

- A.** They provide evidence of the use of bronze weapons.
- B.** They show that children started military training at a young age.
- C.** They indicate that domestication of animals was vital to survival.
- D.** They demonstrate that early humans used tools.

The list below contains some characteristics of early cities.

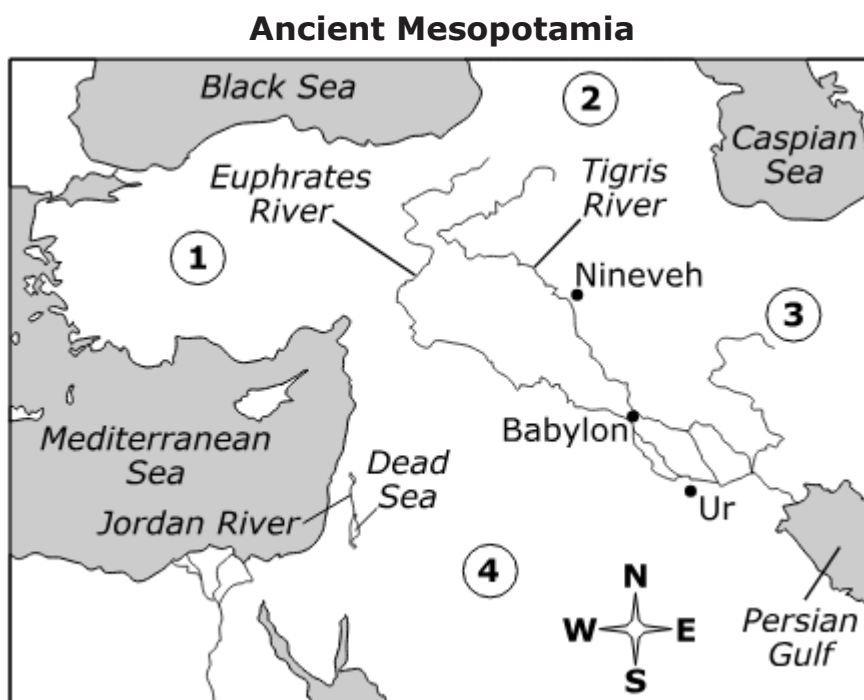
Characteristics of Early Cities

- Trading centers
- Religious sites
- Cultural centers
- Administrative centers

Which conclusion is supported by the list?

- A.** The development of cities caused problems in rural areas.
- B.** The development of cities resulted in military confrontations.
- C.** The development of cities indicated shortages of open spaces.
- D.** The development of cities reflected the emergence of civilization.

The map below shows ancient Mesopotamia.

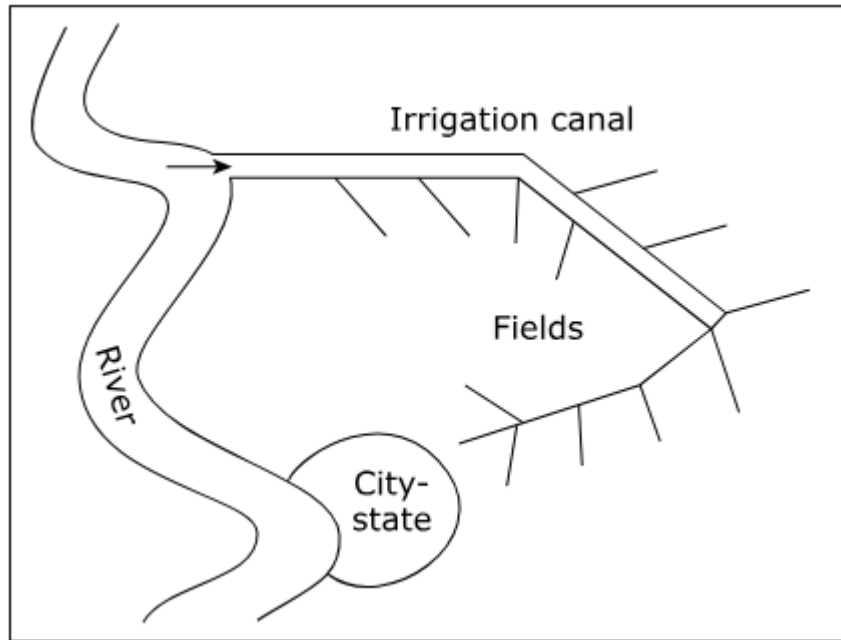


Which number shows the location of the Zagros Mountains?

- A. 1
- B. 2
- C. 3
- D. 4

The illustration below shows an innovation used in Mesopotamia.

Mesopotamian Innovation



Which statement explains how the innovation on the illustration contributed to the growth of civilization in the region?

- A.** by serving as a protective barrier so that it was harder to invade the region
- B.** by helping people to produce more food than they needed for their own use
- C.** by allowing for the faster transportation of goods to market where they could be sold
- D.** by helping people to collect a scarce resource needed for a large urban population to survive

Archaeologists and historians estimate the population of Sumer had grown from 150 people to as many as 100,000 people by 3000 B.C. Which factor allowed this population growth?

- A.** stable food supplies
- B.** widespread open areas
- C.** new scientific discoveries
- D.** increased job opportunities

The excerpt describes the actions of a historical figure.

With the Mesopotamian plain under his control, Sargon . . . led these soldiers in campaign after campaign. . . . He crossed the Tigris and seized the land from the Elamites. . . . Campaigning up the Tigris, he reached and conquered the little northern city of Assur, which had been a center for Ishtar-worship. . . .

Keeping control of this vast expanse of land required a standing army; the men who “ate bread” in Sargon’s presence daily may have been the first professional soldiers in history. . . . He paid tribute to . . . every important local god.

— Susan Wise Bauer, *The History of the Ancient World*

Which sentence identifies the historical significance of Sargon’s reign?

- A.** His rules led to the development of a monotheistic belief system.
- B.** He established the first set of religious edicts for a major civilization.
- C.** His victories led to the establishment of an empire in the region.
- D.** He created the first system of writing that became an alphabet.

The Mesopotamian religion had numerous gods and goddesses. The list below contains a few examples.

Mesopotamian Deities

Ishtar—goddess of love
Nabu—god of scribes and writing
Dumuzi—god of shepherds
Ea—god of fresh water, farming, and building
Gula—goddess of healing

Which conclusion about polytheism is supported by the list?

- A.** Priests promised to get help from the gods.
- B.** People prayed to certain gods based on the need.
- C.** Kings required their subjects to only pray to certain gods.
- D.** People believed prayers to gods always brought good results.

Which statement describes the Epic of Gilgamesh?

- A.** It was an early legal code.
- B.** It was an early Mesopotamian school book.
- C.** It was a work of Mesopotamian literature.
- D.** It was a description of agricultural advances.

Which geographic features influenced the development of Egyptian civilization?

- A.** the Gobi Desert and the Persian Gulf
- B.** the Sahara and the Mediterranean Sea
- C.** the Alps and the Black Sea
- D.** the Zagros Mountains and the Nile Delta

The information below is about ways that early cultures measured the passage of time.

Observing the Sun, the Moon, the planets, and the stars has helped people measure the passage of time since the prehistoric era. By carefully recording the movement of heavenly bodies across the sky, ancient peoples could keep track of the change in seasons and the passing of months and years.

While we have no direct knowledge of how timekeeping developed, historians have found evidence of it in many parts of the world. The earliest evidence is from the Ice Age. It consists of sticks and bones with marks on them. These items may have been used to keep track of the days between moon phases.

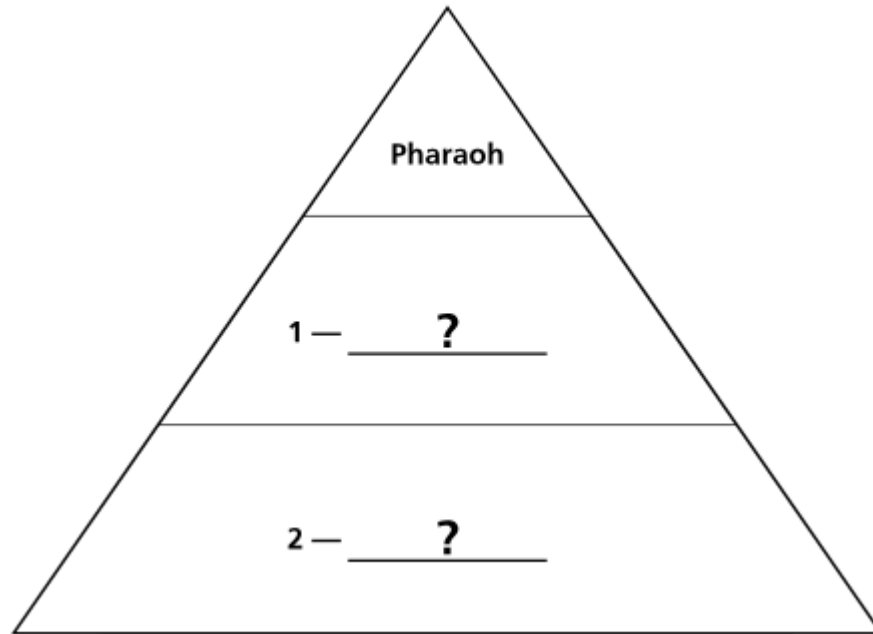
Early civilizations in Mesopotamia had a calendar similar to our own. The Egyptians had a calendar that allowed them to know when the flooding of the Nile began. At Stonehenge in England, the stones are aligned to determine the timing of solstices, which marked the change of seasons. These examples and many more have shown historians that the accurate measurement of time was an important development.

Based on this information, what was a **main** purpose of the Egyptian calendar?

- A.** to schedule when to start military conquests
- B.** to plan the building of royal pyramids
- C.** to decide when to elect pharaohs
- D.** to know when to plant crops

The diagram represents the social structure of Egyptian society.

Egyptian Society



Which classes are correctly identified in the source showing the structure of Egyptian society?

- A.** 1 — Soldiers; 2 — Priests
- B.** 1 — Farmers; 2 — Traders
- C.** 1 — Merchants; 2 — Nobles
- D.** 1 — Peasants; 2 — Slaves

Hatshepsut, who ruled for 20 years, was considered one of the most successful pharaohs. How was the reign of Hatshepsut unique?

- A.** Hatshepsut was the greatest warrior pharaoh.
- B.** Hatshepsut built the greatest burial pyramid.
- C.** Hatshepsut was the first female pharaoh.
- D.** Hatshepsut built the first powerful navy.

Which geographic feature formed the border between ancient Israel and Egypt?

- A.** the Jordan River
- B.** the Sinai Peninsula
- C.** the Zagros Mountains
- D.** the Dead Sea

The diagram describes the migrations of the Israelites.

Migrations of the Israelites



Based on the source, which **two** statements are correct?

- A.** Migration 1: A military defeat forced the Israelites to leave Mesopotamia.
- B.** Migration 2: A widespread famine forced the Israelites to leave Canaan.
- C.** Migration 3: The Israelites gained freedom from slavery in Egypt.
- D.** Migration 1: An increase in population led the Israelites to seek land in Canaan.
- E.** Migration 3: The overthrow of an empire allowed the Israelites to return to Canaan.

Which action of King Solomon helped unite the tribes of Israel?

- A.** ordering that sacred texts be written in Hebrew so all the tribes could learn the same lessons
- B.** building a place of worship in Jerusalem that served as a meeting place for the tribes
- C.** creating a common currency to make it easier for the tribes to trade with each other
- D.** ordering that members of all the tribes migrate as a group to Mesopotamia

The passage below discusses events after the breakup of ancient Israel into two kingdoms.

The Kingdom of Israel became two separate kingdoms. Ten of the twelve Hebrew tribes stayed in the northern part of the old kingdom. They kept the name the Kingdom of Israel. The other two Hebrew tribes established the Kingdom of Judah in the region to the south that included the city of Jerusalem.

The northern Kingdom of Israel lasted about 250 years before it was conquered by the Assyrians. The Assyrians then broke up the ten tribes that lived in the kingdom and made them depart from their homeland. As was their practice, the Assyrians scattered the former residents of the Kingdom of Israel across their territory.

Unlike the Kingdom of Israel, the Kingdom of Judah successfully defended itself from the Assyrian conquests. It lasted about another 150 years before it was conquered by Nebuchadnezzar, the king of the Babylonians. When the Babylonians captured the Kingdom of Judah, they took over Jerusalem, destroyed the temple, and resettled many Jews in their homeland of Mesopotamia. They made Judah a province of their territory, which ended the political freedom of the Jewish people.

About 30 years later, the Persians invaded the region and captured it from the Babylonians. Although he kept possession of the region, the Persian ruler, Cyrus the Great, allowed the Jews that had been removed from their homeland to return there. He also allowed them to rebuild their temple. The Jews lived for the next two centuries under Persian rule.

Which statement explains how the Persians' conquest of Jewish territory was different from that of the other empires?

- A.** The Persians allowed the Jews to keep their political independence.
- B.** The Persians allowed the Jews to preserve their cultural heritage.
- C.** The Persians forced the Jews to reunite their kingdoms.
- D.** The Persians forced the Jews to leave their kingdoms.

Which geographic feature forms a physical barrier along northern India?

- A.** Himalaya Mountains
- B.** Zagros Mountains
- C.** Ganges River
- D.** Indus River

The list below relates to the traditional caste system in India.

Traditional Caste System

Brahmins—kings, priests, and clergy

Kshatriyas—military leaders and warriors

Vaisyas—merchants, minor officials, skilled traders, and farm owners

Sudras—servants, farm workers, and peasants

Pariahs (Dalits) —garbage workers and leather workers

Which statement explains the effects of the caste system on ancient Indian society?

- A.** Caste levels applied mainly to people in rural areas.
- B.** Religious followers were members of the highest caste.
- C.** Marriage offered an opportunity to move to higher castes.
- D.** Caste levels were directly related to occupation types.

Which feature of the Hindu-Arabic numeral system was an improvement over previous numeral systems?

- A.** the concept of zero
- B.** the use of prime numbers
- C.** the development of number lines
- D.** the creation of multiplication tables

Which statement explains how geographic features affected ancient China?

- A.** Establishing a strong central government was difficult.
- B.** Trade networks were widespread in the southern regions.
- C.** Military defense relied on technology rather than terrain.
- D.** Advances in agriculture were limited to the western regions.

The paragraph below describes an advancement of the Han dynasty.

When the Han dynasty came to power, ancient China already had a bureaucracy. The Han recognized that the bureaucracy was helpful in performing the day-to-day business of government. However, they wanted to change how the bureaucracy was selected. The Han decided to establish a civil service system. Under this system, a young man wanting a government job first had to pass a long, difficult exam testing his knowledge of Chinese law and literature.

How did the civil service system benefit the Han dynasty?

- A.** Rich families bought government positions.
- B.** Jobs went to people with family businesses.
- C.** The wisest scholars became government workers.
- D.** The people chosen by the emperor got the best jobs.

Which statement describes the **main** reason trade routes to Europe expanded during the Han Dynasty?

- A.** Europeans sought gold for jewelry.
- B.** Europeans valued silk for clothing.
- C.** Chinese wanted books on papyrus.
- D.** Chinese wanted diamonds for rings.

The paragraph below describes the physical geography of ancient Greece.

Geography provided ancient Greece with a unique physical setting. Being on a peninsula allowed every part of Greece to be near the sea. The irregular coastline and nearby islands offered many sheltered harbors. Short mountain ranges divided the interior into small sections. Greece also had a mild climate and plenty of rainfall. However, the Greeks struggled to raise enough food for everyone, especially as the population grew.

Which statement explains how the ancient Greeks overcame the problem discussed in the paragraph?

- A.** Farmers developed new types of crops.
- B.** Merchants established overseas trade networks.
- C.** Leaders resettled most of the people to island colonies.
- D.** Engineers created flat plains by leveling most of the mountains.

Which statement describes a difference between life in ancient Athens and life in ancient Sparta?

- A.** Support for the arts was more important in Sparta.
- B.** Military training was more important in Sparta.
- C.** Science was less important in Athens.
- D.** Trade was less important in Athens.

Which phrase identifies the reason that the ancient Greeks began holding the Olympic Games?

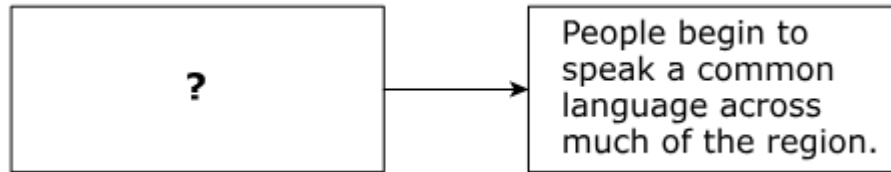
- A.** to choose the leader of a city-state
- B.** to promote long-distance trade
- C.** to learn work skills
- D.** to honor the gods

Where was the Parthenon built?

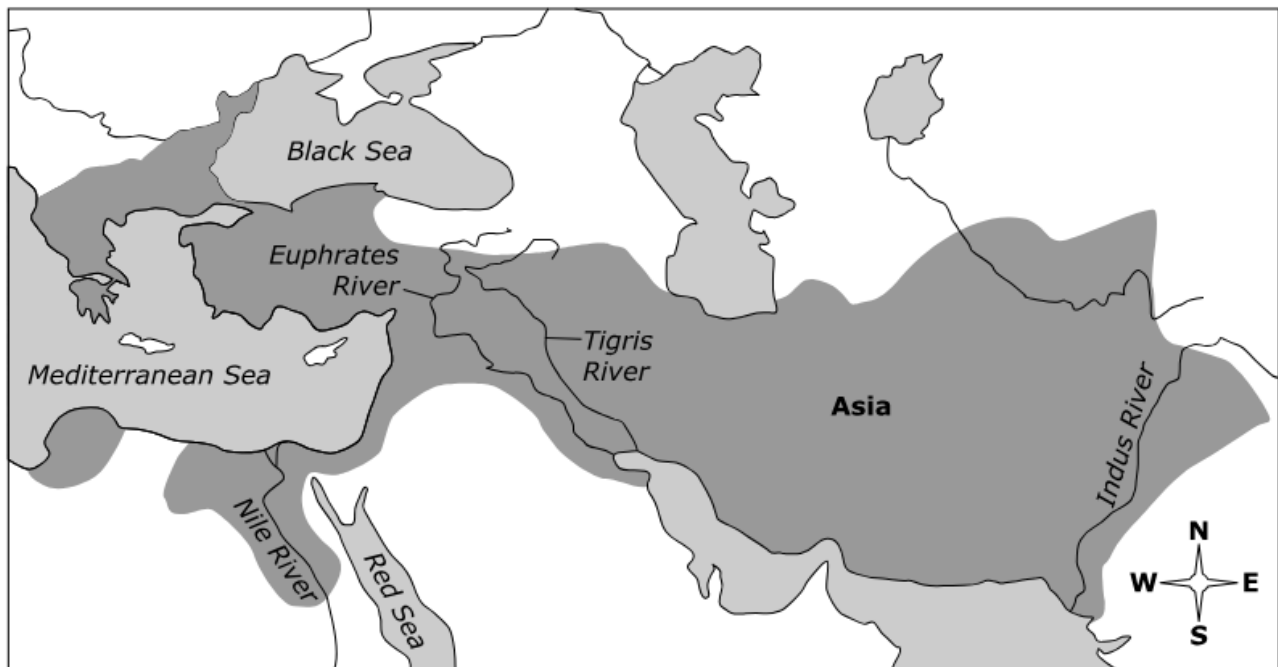
- A.** in a city-state in ancient Mesopotamia
- B.** in a city-state in ancient Greece
- C.** in the capital of ancient Rome
- D.** in the capital of ancient Israel

The diagram below is about an event that took place in the region shown on the map during the 300s B.C.

Historic Event



Southwest Asia



Which statement **best** completes the diagram?

- A. Hebrews adopt elements of cultures from different continents.
- B. Hellenistic culture blends with cultures from different continents.
- C. Aryan culture replaces traditional culture in southwest Asia.
- D. The Han spread their culture across Asia.

The list below shows some aspects of an ancient civilization.

?

- public baths
- arenas for entertainment
- monuments with arches
- central heating and indoor plumbing
- sewage systems

Which title belongs with this list?

- A.** Features of Roman Cities
- B.** Mesopotamian Inventions
- C.** Improvements by Egyptian Leaders
- D.** Technologies of the Ancient Greeks

Which **two** events led to the Diaspora of Jewish people in 70 AD?

- A.** destruction of the temple in Jerusalem
- B.** occupation of the Sinai Peninsula
- C.** loss of territory after a war with the Egyptians
- D.** expulsion of citizens to Mesopotamia
- E.** failure of revolts against the Romans

Metadata- Social Studies Items

Page Number	Item Type	Key	TN Standards
1	MC	B	6.01
2	MC	D	6.02
3	MC	D	6.04
4	MC	C	6.05
5	MC	B	6.07
6	MC	A	6.08
7	MC	C	6.09
8	MC	B	6.10
9	MC	C	6.11
10	MC	B	6.13
11	MC	D	6.14
12	MC	D	6.15
13	MC	C	6.17
14	MC	B	6.20
15	MS	B,C	6.21
16	MC	B	6.23
17	MC	B	6.24
18	MC	A	6.25
19	MC	D	6.27
20	MC	A	6.30
21	MC	A	6.32
22	MC	C	6.36
23	MC	B	6.38
24	MC	B	6.40
25	MC	B	6.43
26	MC	D	6.46
27	MC	B	6.49
28	MC	B	6.50
29	MC	A	6.57
30	MS	A, E	6.60
Metadata Definitions			
Item Type	Indicates type of item. MC = Multiple Choice, MS = Multiple Select		
Key	Correct Answer		
TN Standards	Primary educational standard assessed.		